



TOTAL MEDALS AT STAKE

6

attackers. Since the 2023 Asian Games, only Abhishek Nain has remained a threat, notching up 30 goals in 86 appearances, while senior forward Manpreet Singh's returns have dwindled to just 11 goals in 69.

Fulton lamented his side's struggles to maintain its standards across all four quarters, but will breathe a little easier knowing the continent's contenders might not have the sustained quality to punish its lapses. With an Olympic berth up for grabs, Fulton has opted for more experience in the squad, with Aditya Lalage making way for Raj Kumar Pal, who was part of the travelling group at the World Cup.

Early tests against host nation Japan and South Korea in the group phase will help assess if India has learnt from its misadventures in the World Cup, before likely coming up against Pakistan or Malaysia in the knockout stages.

Aiming to reign supreme

In the women's section, Sjoerd Marijne's India will feel primed to go for gold, confident of dethroning

China. There is a renewed spirit within this group, infused with a vibrant mix of youth and older heads after exceeding expectations with its disciplined World Cup showing.

India kept clean sheets against England and Australia, while conceding just six goals in matches against China, South Africa, Netherlands and Germany. Of the six opponents it faced, five were ranked higher.

Better composure on the ball against Australia might have seen this side compete in the semifinals, but the young team, which had 11 World Cup debutants, will take those learnings into the Asian Games.

Navneet Kaur and Deepika will be the biggest source of goals, both from open play and PCs, while matches in the group stage against lower-quality opposition will give the rest of the attack opportunities to contribute.

India has two strong goalkeepers, Savita Punia and Bichu Devi, whose services will likely be crucial in the medal rounds with a potential meeting against China. India showed

Historic high: Salima Tete's side stunned World No. 5 Germany 3-1 in Amstelveen to secure their best World Cup finish since 1974, signing off in style with a historic fifth-place finish.

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it can match up to China in the opening match of the World Cup, earning a 2-2 draw, but inexperience in defence proved costly when Shilpi Dabas conceded a Penalty Stroke.

Senior midfielder Neha is bullish about India's chances of ending its 44-year gold medal drought at this stage. "We have to win the gold medal. No matter what happens, we will give our best. We will win the gold medal," said Neha.

Marijne, who is overseeing another renaissance with the women's side, felt this group of Indian talent might be better than the group he managed during his first stint in charge. But the class of 2026 will have to earn that billing on the pitch by following up its impressive fifth-place finish at the World Cup with a rare Asian Games gold.